

There isn't much that can be said about the Pokémon franchise that hasn't been said already. It is one of the most successful franchises on the planet, scratch that, it IS the most successful franchise on the planet for a reason. The multi-billion dollar franchise (now worth well over USD 100 billion) which has only been around since 1996 played a big role in bringing the east and west together. Along with *Dragon Ball* and *Sailor Moon*, Pokémon was responsible for popularising anime in the west. It's the second highest-grossing video game franchise of all time, behind only its bigger brother, *Mario*. It is the highest-grossing entertainment franchise of all time, period, across all mediums, including video games, books, TV and more. So how did Pokémon get to where it is now? What were its humble beginnings and how was the journey to the top. Let's dive into the Pokéverse and find out.

In the beginning

Pokémon is the brain-child of one Satoshi Tajiri, who as a child, was rather fond of catching insects and tadpoles. It was this childhood activity that would be the spark for what would go on to become a global phenomenon.

To make his dream a reality, Tajiri would form *Game Freak*, and later, a design studio called *Creatures inc.*, along with his friends Ken Sugimori, Junichi Masuda, and others. Most of us have probably never heard of Sugimori, Masuda, or even Tajiri for that matter, but Sugimori is the illustrator of the original artwork for the Pokémon games. He also worked on concept art for the Pokémon movies and illustrated the Pokémon trading cards. Full credit for the original 151 Pokémon goes to Sugimori. Masuda on the other hand was responsible for composing the music and sound effects in the video games.

Anyway, after having formed *Game Freak*, it was time to conceptualise the game. The *Nintendo Game Boy* was a popular handheld console at the time,

and the *Link Cable* further fueled Tajiri's imagination, as he could just picture insects travelling along the wire between players. And so, Tajiri came up with "*Capsule Monsters*" which he would go on to pitch to Nintendo. Which Nintendo would reject, several times. Yikes.

Of course, all was not lost. Nintendo would eventually agree to fund the project after a certain Shigeru Miyamoto took an interest in the idea and pitched it to the company.



Shigeru Miyamoto
 Rivalled only by Lord Gaben himself

Miyamoto had a few interesting ideas of his own for the Pokémon franchise, ideas which are still practised to this day. It was his idea to have paired versions of the Pokémon games, which is why to this day we see two releases of Pokémon games. The reasoning was, in order to emphasise the trading aspect of the game, players would need to link up with friends in order to actually "catch them all!"

For his contributions to the franchise, he has been immortalised alongside Satoshi Tajiri in both the games and the anime. In case you didn't know, in the original Japanese version of the anime, Ash Ketchum is named Satoshi, and his rival, who we know as Gary, is named Shigeru. Similarly, one of the default names for the rivals across all generations of the Pokémon games is Shigeru.

Gen 1 – Global domination begins at home

Initial sales for the first two Pokémon games were actually pretty modest. The Pokémon games did have some-

things up their sleeve though. Once debugging for the game was complete, Shigeki Morimoto programmed a 151st Pokémon – Mew – into the game. The idea was to reveal it as a post-launch event. That turned out to be a stonks move, as a magazine called *CoroCoro* announced a contest of which twenty entrants would get a Mew. 78,000 people(!) entered, and Pokémon sales shot through the roof.

The rise in popularity saw the release of *Pokémon Blue*, which was basically an improved version of *Red* and *Green*, with better graphics and sound. Eventually, the first set of Pokémon TCG (Trading Card Game) cards would also be developed, with its own set of rules. Even the cards became incredibly popular, and they still are to this day, with collectors willing to spend hundreds of thousands of dollars on rare or limited edition cards.

When it came to other media, several *manga* adaptations of Pokémon were beginning to spawn, but it would be the anime series that was first aired on October 28, 1997 in Japan, that would shoot the Pokémon franchise to the moon. The anime would quickly propel Pokémon's popularity in Japan, and soon, *Pokémon Centre* stores, named after the *Pokémon Centres* in the game of course, would start popping up in Japan. *Pokémon Centres* specialised in Pokémon merchandise, including the video games, they also sold toys, cards, *mangas*, tabletop games and just about anything Pokémon-related you can think of. The first *Pokémon Centre* would open in Tokyo in 1998, and a new company, *The Pokémon Company*, would be founded to handle merchandising and the subsequent Pokémon stores that were planned to open in Japan and throughout the world.

Step 2 - World domination

In just two years, Pokémon was a phenomenon in Japan, so the next step was a no-brainer. It was time to go global. In September 1998, *Pokémon Red* and *Blue* would release in North America, and the slogan "Gotta Catch 'em All!" would be coined. Even the